

Who Pays and Who Decides: A Better Question

谁承担，谁决定：更好的问题

Theme: 社会问题、经济与公共生活 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6,127

English Story

The better question was announced in **parliament** and **then** repeated in a **conversation** on the steps: who decides what a household needs? “We **prefer** to ask how much water is **missing**,” the member said. “We should ask who is entitled to it.” The **launch** of the new tariff was, **ultimately**, a **launch** of a different question.

The **strange** part was how little it took to **convince** the room. “You can **devise** a rate that corresponds to a real bill,” the economist said. “A **proposition** with a **definite** number beats a **certainty** with none.” The **contradiction** at the heart of the old system was that it was both **conclusive** and **wasteful**.

“We **proclaim validity** and we cannot **verify** the meter,” the clerk said. “We **infer mastery** from a **conquest** of paperwork.” The **generosity** of the old exemption was, in fact, **economical only** for the rich, and **anyhow** nobody had ever checked the **verification**.

The **final** draft was shorter by half, and its **permanence** was the point. “A rule that survives a change of government is worth more than a rule that sucks up the whole budget,” the chair said. “We have hidden behind a **falsehood**: that a complicated form is a fair one.”

The **inducement** to cheat was the exemption itself. “Where there is **hiding**, there is a **lie**,” Maya wrote. “Where there is a **definite** limit, there is a defensible argument.” The **missing** element was not money but room: a level at which a poor household could still pay.

The invitation to the public was issued under the new rule, and the first question at the meeting was the better one. The end of the session, the government and the market on the same page, the result of the whole period: a question about need rather than about price. The **adventure** of the **launch** was that it could **fail**; the **final conversation**, the **strange proposition**, and the **missing** number all had to **correspond** to something real. We would rather be **conclusive** than generous, and **ultimately** that was the **inducement** we had to remove. **Then** the **parliament** would **announce** the figure **publicly**. If we now validate the rule, we can show the party that the law, the interest, and the policy are on the right side; it would be **contradictory to attain permanence** without an **infinity** of patience. The social world and the state would have to agree before the level changed.

中文翻译

那个更好的问题在议会里被宣布，随后又在台阶上的一场交谈里被重复：谁来决定一个家庭需要什么？“我们更愿意问缺多少水，”那位议员说，“我们应该问谁有权得到它。”新费率的启动，说到底是一个不同问题的启动。

奇怪之处在于说服这间屋子所需的東西如此之少。“你可以设计一个与真实账单相符的费率，”经济学家说，“一个带明确数字的提议胜过一种没有数字的确定性。”旧体系核心处的矛盾是：它既是决定性的，又是浪费的。

“我们宣告有效性，却无法核实水表，”职员说，“我们从一堆文书的征服中推断出精通。”旧豁免的慷慨其实只对富人合算，而且无论如何从来没有人核对过那项验证。

最终稿缩短了一半，而它的持久性正是要点。“一条能挺过政府更替的规则，比一条吸干整个预算的规则更有价值，”主席说，“我们一直躲在一个谎言后面：复杂表格就是公平表格。”

作弊的诱因就是豁免本身。“有隐匿的地方就有谎言，”曼雅写道，“有明确限值的地方就有可辩护的论证。”缺失的不是钱而是空间：一个贫穷家庭仍然付得起的水平。

对公众的邀请在新规则下发出，而会上的第一个问题就是那个更好的问题。这场会议的结束、政府与市场在同一页上、整个时期的结果：一个关于需要而非关于价格的问题。这次发布的冒险之处在于它可能失败；最后的对话、那个奇怪的提议，以及那个缺失的数字，都必须与某种真实的東西相符。我们宁愿做决定性的那个，也不愿做慷慨的那个，而说到底，那正是我们必须移除的诱因。然后议会会公开宣布这个数字。如果我们现在验证这条规则，我们就能向那个党表明：法律、利益和政策都在正确的一边；没有无限的耐心而想获得持久，是自相矛盾的。社会世界与国家必须先取得一致，水平才会改变。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
then ðen POS: adv	adv. 然后, 当时; conj. 然后, 当时; n. 那时 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. that time; that moment; s. at a specific prior time; r. subsequently or soon afterward (often used as senten...
only 'əunli POS: a	a. 唯一的, 仅有的, 最佳的; adv. 只有, 仅仅, 只能; conj. 但是, 不过 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. with nevertheless the final result; r. in the final outcome; r. except that; only this time she came out bet...
lie lai POS: n	n. 谎言, 假象, 位置; vi. 躺着, 说谎, 位于, 展现, 存在, 停泊; vt. 欺骗 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a statement that deviates from or perverts the truth; n. Norwegian diplomat who was the first Secretary Gen...
fail feil POS: vi	vi. 失败, 缺乏, 中断, 衰退, 失灵; vt. 忘记, 使...失望, 缺乏, 不及格; n. 不及格 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. fail to do something; leave something undone; v. be unsuccessful; v. disappoint, prove undependable to; aban...
final 'faɪnəl POS: n	n. 期末考试, 结局, 决赛; a. 最后的, 终极的, 决定性的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the final match between the winners of all previous matches in an elimination tournament; s. conclusive in...
announce ə'naʊns POS: vt	vt. 宣布, 声称, 显示, 预告; vi. 当报幕员, 宣布参加竞选 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. make known; make an announcement; v. announce publicly or officially; v. give the names of; v. foreshadow or...
parliament 'pɑ:ləmənt POS: n	n. 国会, 议会; [法] 会议, 国会, 议院 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a legislative assembly in certain countries
conversation .kɒnvə'seɪʃən POS: n	n. 会话, 说话, 交谈; [法] 交谈, 社交, 性交 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the use of speech for informal exchange of views or ideas or information etc.
prefer prɪ'feɪ POS: vt	vt. 宁可, 较喜欢, 提出; [法] 给予优先权, 优先偿还, 提出 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. like better; value more highly; v. promote over another; v. give preference to one creditor over another
strange streɪndʒ POS: a	a. 奇怪的, 陌生的, 生疏的, 不熟悉的, 不可思议的, 外行的, 外地的, 异乡的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. being definitely out of the ordinary and unexpected; slightly odd or even a bit weird; s. not known before
launch lɔ:ntʃ POS: n	n. 下水, 汽艇, 发射; vt. 使下水, 发射, 发动; vi. 起飞, 下水, 投入, 开始 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a motorboat with an open deck or a half deck; v. propel with force; v. launch for the first time; launch on...
ultimately 'ʌltɪməli POS: adv	adv. 最后, 最终; [法] 最后, 终究, 总之 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. as the end result of a succession or process
convince kən'vɪns POS: vt	vt. 说服, 使相信; [法] 使确信, 使信服, 使人认识错误 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v make (someone) agree, understand, or realize the truth or validity of something
adventure əd'ventʃə POS: n	n. 冒险, 冒险经历; v. 冒险 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a wild and exciting undertaking (not necessarily lawful)
entitle ɪn'taɪtl POS: vt	vt. 给...权利, 取名为, 给予名称, 叫做; [法] 给...权利, 使有资格, 称呼 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. give the right to; v. give a title to
publicly 'pʌblɪkli POS: adv	adv. 公然地, 以公众名义 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. in a manner accessible to or observable by the public; openly; r. by the public or the people generally
devise dɪ'vaɪz POS: vt	vt. 设计, 发明, 图谋, 遗赠给; n. 遗赠 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a will disposing of real property; n. (law) a gift of real property by will; v. give by will, especially rea...
correspond .kɒrɪ'spɒnd POS: vi	vi. 符合, 通信, 相当; [法] 符合, 一致, 相当 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. exchange messages
missing 'mɪsɪŋ POS: a	a. 不见的, 缺少的; [法] 行踪不明的, 失踪的, 遗失的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. not able to be found
proposition .prəpə'zɪʃən POS: n	n. 建议, 命题, 主张; vt. 向...提议, 向...提出猥褻的要求 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (logic) a statement that affirms or denies something and is either true or false; n. an offer for a private...
suck sʌk POS: vt	vt. 吸, 吮, 吸入, 吮吸, 吸收; vi. 吸, 吸奶; n. 吸, 吸入, 吮吸 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. draw into the mouth by creating a practical vacuum in the mouth; v. draw something in by or as if by a vacu...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
definite 'definit POS: a	a. 明确的, 一定的; [法] 明确的, 确切的, 一定的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. precise; explicit and clearly defined; s. known for certain
certainly 'sə:təntli POS: n	n. 确定, 确实的事情; [法] 确定, 肯定, 必然的事 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the state of being certain; n. something that is certain
contradiction ,kɒntrə'dɪkʃən POS: n	n. 反驳, 矛盾; [法] 矛盾, 否认, 反驳 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. opposition between two conflicting forces or ideas; n. (logic) a statement that is necessarily false; n. the...
proclaim prə'kleɪm POS: vt	vt. 宣布, 公告, 宣言, 表明, 赞扬; [法] 宣布, 宣告, 公布 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. declare formally; declare someone to be something; of titles; v. state or announce
validity və'lɪdɪti POS: n	n. 有效性, 正确性; [计] 有效性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the quality of having legal force or effectiveness
attain ə'teɪn POS: vt	vt. 达到, 获得; vi. 达到 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v to gain with effort; v reach a point in time, or a certain state or level; v find unexpectedly; v reach a dest...
verify 'verɪfaɪ POS: vt	vt. 证明, 查证, 证实, 检验, 校验; [计] 校验, 检验; DOS内部命令: 设定写入磁盘时是否验证写入的正确性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. confirm the truth of; v. attach or append a legal verification to (a pleading or petition)
conquest 'kɒŋkwɛst POS: n	n. 战胜, 征服, 战利品; [法] 征服, 赢得, 获得 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of conquering; n. success in mastering something difficult
contradictory ,kɒntrə'dɪktəri POS: a	a. 反驳的, 反对的, 抗辩的; n. 矛盾因素, 对立物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. two propositions are contradictory if both cannot be true (or both cannot be false) at the same time; s. ...
infer ɪn'fɜː POS: vt	vt. 推论出, 推断; vi. 作推论 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v reason by deduction; establish by deduction; v draw from specific cases for more general cases; v conclude by...
validate 'vælədeɪt POS: vt	vt. 使有效, 使生效, 确认, 证实, 验证; [计] 验证 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. declare or make legally valid; v. prove valid; show or confirm the validity of something; v. give evidence f...
mastery 'mɑːstəri POS: n	n. 征服, 统治权, 优势, 精通, 掌握; [法] 统治权, 控制权, 征服 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of mastering or subordinating someone
generosity ,dʒenə'rɒsɪti POS: n	n. 慷慨, 宽大 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the trait of being willing to give your money or time; n. acting generously
economical ,i:kə'nɒmɪkəl POS: a	a. 节俭的, 经济的, 合算的; [经] 经济的, 节约的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. avoiding waste
anyhow 'enihaʊ POS: adv	adv. 无论如何, 至少 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: r. used to indicate that a statement explains or supports a previous statement; anyhow, they're quiet"; anywa...
conclusive kən'kluːsɪv POS: a	a. 决定性的, 确定性的, 最后的; [法] 决定性的, 不容置疑的, 确实的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. forming an end or termination; especially putting an end to doubt or question
verification ,verɪfɪ'keɪʃən POS: n	n. 证实, 查证, 证明属实; [计] 验证 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (law) an affidavit attached to a statement confirming the truth of that statement
wasteful 'weɪstfʊl POS: a	a. 浪费的, 不经济的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. tending to squander and waste; s. laying waste
infinity ɪn'fɪnɪti POS: n	n. 无限大, 无限; [计] 无穷 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n time without end
inducement ɪn'djuːsmənt POS: n	n. 诱因, 动机, 吸引力, 刺激物; [法] 诱惑, 引诱, 诱因 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. act of bringing about a desired result
hiding 'haɪdɪŋ POS: n	n. 隐匿, 隐藏之事, 隐匿之所, 痛打; [法] 躲藏, 躲藏处 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the state of being hidden
permanence 'pɜːmənəns POS: n	n. 永久, 持久, 固定性; [法] 永久性, 持久性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the property of being able to exist for an indefinite duration
falsehood 'fɔːlshʊd POS: n	n. 谎言, 虚假(性); [法] 虚伪陈述, 谎言, 谬误 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a false statement